

HINDUSTAN TIMES/VINAYAK RAUT



goes against Maharashtrian culture," he says. Chief Minister Vilasrao Deshmukh also refrained from openly criticising Raj, assuring people that the Government would "take strict action against those creating tension over issues of regionalism". Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar compared Raj to the devil. "Raj Thackeray is like a *shaitan* who is in the habit of making such remarks to be in the news."

Political observers feel Raj's outburst is nothing but retaliation against cousin Uddhav's pro-migrant drive. Ever since it came into existence, MNS has been quietly slipping off Maharashtra's political map. After a poor performance in the corporation elections, there has been an exodus of workers from the party and many, who had left Sena two years ago to join this new organisation, are now heading back. Ironically, those who have deserted him accuse him of doing the same that he had criticised Uddhav of doing when he was a part of the Shiv Sena, that is promoting a coterie culture. On February 6, around 200 members of MNS joined the Sena at a function held at the

ACTION TIME: Police lathicharge MNS supporters in Shivaji Park party supremo's residence Matoshree in suburban Bandra, Sena secretary Vinayak Raut said. "Raj plays kitchen politics, doesn't have any party ideology or concrete issues to take up. That explains why he keeps changing his stance every now and then," says a Shiv Sainik who returned after a year's stint in the Navnirman Sena.

Interestingly, while MNS is rewinding to the original Thackeray's 40-year-old posturing, the Shiv Sena itself has abandoned its anti-migrant rant. It is now trying to cash in on the growing



"When even Amitabh Bachchan isn't safe, one can imagine the plight of common Mumbaikars."

AMAR SINGH SP GEN SECY



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NITISH KUMAR CM, BIHAR



"He is frustrated because people are leaving him. He is facing political isolation and has no vote bank."

ABU ASIM AZMI SP LEADER

north-Indian vote bank in urban Maharashtra. Out of Mumbai's total population of 16 million, over 4.5 million are north Indians, a decisive vote bank that can make or break the fortunes of any political party. It is this sizeable chunk of votes that the Sena now wants to tap to help regain the political glory of the past. This is also the reason why the party is quietly shedding its rigid Maratha image to welcome "outsiders" into its fold. "They have realised that they won't be able to survive only with Marathi votes. This is why the Sena is trying to befriend them," says Sanjay Nirupam, a former Shiv Sainik who has now joined the Congress and who was once a close aide of the Sena boss.

Shiv Sena's *Mee Mumbaikar* campaign—to prevent non-Maharashtrians from settling down in Mumbai—failed in the 2004 elections, which forced it to extend an olive branch to them. In recent times, Uddhav has been attending *uttar bharatiya* meetings and celebrations, in preparation for the next elections. The speeches against non-Marathis—popular at Sena rallies till the 1980s—have been replaced by a softer stance. And the party has even decided to give Bhojpuri films a tax exemption. Senior Nationalist Congress Party Minister Chhagan Bhujbal, who quit the Sena in 1991, says: "Over a period of time, the Sena has diluted its rigid, only-Marathi stand to expand its base by including non-Maharashtrians."

The Sena's efforts to woo the north Indians may have borne fruit in the 2007 civic elections but the party is careful not to offend its loyal voters. The party supremo recently demanded 50 per cent quota for Maharashtrians in all new residential projects. Sanjay Raut stresses that his party believes in "inclusive politics", but Nirupam is quick to dismiss this change of heart as a "political gimmick" before elections.

Whether the north Indian will give the Sena a chance or stick to the Congress and BJP or possibly try out SP and Bahujan Samaj Party is something only time will tell. Till then, the state's two Maharashtrian parties continue to be locked in a power struggle.